

The Ethiopian Crown Council Call

Full debrief, delegation dossiers, the September New York opening, the January expedition, the support ask, and the pathway to a real partnership.

PREPARED BY	B. Amechi — Manager, 19Keys · Co-Founder, High Lvl Media
PREPARED FOR	19Keys · ChakaBars · Omega Axsal — Ethiopia delegation leadership
CALL DATE	Sunday, 6 September 2026 — 4:00 PM ET / 1:00 PM PT, Zoom (hosted by Scheril Murray Powell, Esq.)
ATTENDEES	Scheril Murray Powell, Esq. · Deacon Solomon Kibriye · Lij Nebyat Aklilu Demessie · B. Amechi
SUBJECTS	Meskel in New York, 26–27 September 2026 · The Ethiopia New Year Expedition, 5–15 January 2027
DOCUMENT DATE	6 September 2026 · Version 1.0

INTERNAL DOCUMENT

This version contains cost figures, strategy, risk analysis and a direct challenge section. It is for 19Keys, ChakaBars, Omega Axsal and the core team only. A separate partner-facing version has been prepared for Ms. Murray Powell, Deacon Solomon Kibriye and Lij Nebyat Demessie. Do not send this file to the Crown Council delegation.

01 Bottom Line Up Front

A representative of the Ethiopian Crown Council opened a direct line to the House of Haile Selassie, and she is not gatekeeping it. Two events sit in front of us: a historic Meskel weekend in New York on 26–27 September, twenty days out, and our own eleven-day Ethiopia expedition in January. The Crown side wants a diaspora platform. We want authority, access, provenance and support. Both sides have exactly what the other is short on.

- **What is confirmed.** 19Keys and guests are on the invited guest list for the 27 September Abyssinian Baptist Church service. A formal letter of invitation is coming. The 26 September Meskel bonfire in Newark is an open event, no cap.
- **What is escalated but not confirmed.** A seat at the small private luncheon after the 27 September service, and direct dialogue between 19Keys and His Imperial Highness Prince Ermias Sahle-Selassie. Deacon Solomon Kibriye said on the call he is “pretty certain” the luncheon invitation will be extended.
- **What has not been discussed at all.** Money. Not one dollar figure was raised on either side. There is no speaking fee, no travel support, no media budget and no sponsorship on the table yet, because nobody asked. That conversation is ours to open, and it should be opened once, clearly, in writing, before the next call.
- **The commercial prize is not the trip.** It is provenance. Supermind is a coffee brand whose origin story is Ethiopia. A relationship with the Imperial house and the Royal Ethiopian Trust is the one asset a competitor cannot buy, copy or outspend. Section 11 lays out the ladder.
- **The single biggest risk is political.** The Crown Council’s stated long-term goal, said plainly on this call, is restoration of the monarchy. We are simultaneously courting the Ethiopian government and tourism bodies with the same Ethiopia partner deck. We need one written position on this before the next call, or we will be asked to pick a side in front of both.
- **The decision needed from 19Keys this week.** Yes or no on New York, 26–27 September — and if yes, who travels. B. Amechi’s position: we go regardless of funding, because the content and the room are worth more than the cost.

02 How This Connection Was Made

Scheril Murray Powell, Esq. met B. Amechi and 19Keys at a 19Keys tour stop in New York on **1 October 2025**. She introduced herself that night as International President of The Ethiopian World Federation, Incorporated, and as a cannabis, agricultural, dietary supplement, trade and psychedelic attorney. She followed up by text the next morning and was pointed to **19keys@19keys.com**.

Over the following months she stayed consistent rather than transactional, which matters. She reported that she was building an Ethiopian World Federation proposal to partner its Juvenile Units with 19Keys initiatives, that she had onboarded a Director for the EWF Freedom School who would help develop that proposal, and that she was sending the EWF International Treasurer to the 19Keys London show so that the Treasurer could see the vision firsthand. She committed to delivering a draft proposal approximately one week after the London tour stop.

She then made the move that created this call: she offered to introduce 19Keys to **His Imperial Highness Prince Ermias Sahle-Selassie Haile-Selassie**, grandson of Emperor Haile Selassie I, in New York on Sunday 27 September. B. Amechi replied that a January Ethiopia trip was already booked and invited her onto it. She responded with an invitation to a meeting with representatives of the Crown Council and the Royal Ethiopian Trust, placed 19Keys on the 27 September guest list, promised a formal letter of invitation, and agreed to include ChakaBars on the list at B. Amechi's request.

Before the call, B. Amechi sent her the Africa Plus mission page and the Ethiopia section, and told her plainly that the Ethiopia partner information is still being assembled. She replied that she would read it beforehand, that she has "great contacts across the continent," and that she is happy to support the initiatives on behalf of the Crown Council of Ethiopia and as a representative of the African diaspora. That is an unprompted offer of institutional endorsement. Do not let it go unused.

03 Who Was In The Room

Everything below that is sourced to the call is what they said about themselves. Everything marked as public record has been checked against published sources, listed in Section 14. Read the difference carefully — it is where the research assignments come from.

Scheril Murray Powell, Esq. — the convener

- **Stated roles:** Special Representative to the African Diaspora for the Crown Council of Ethiopia. International President of The Ethiopian World Federation, Incorporated. Attorney in cannabis, agriculture, dietary supplements, trade and psychedelics.
- **Public record:** Adjunct professor at NYU teaching cannabis and social equity policy. Founder and President of Green Sustainable Strong and Canna Headhunters. Founder of the Cannabis HR Council. Former Director of Federal Affairs at the Florida Department of Agriculture and Consumer Services. Former Executive Director of the African American Farmers Association. Former COO of the JUSTÜS Foundation. Founding board member of the U.S. Hemp Building Association. Sits on a Jamaican Bureau of Standards cannabis committee.
- **Why she matters to us:** Agriculture plus trade plus Caribbean and West African government relationships is the exact skill stack Africa Plus needs and does not have in-house. She has worked on cannabis as an inclusive economic growth vehicle in Ghana. She is a trade lawyer who already thinks in corridors.
- **VERIFY** On the call, Deacon Solomon referred to her as “the former president of the EWF.” Her own text says International President. Confirm her current officer status before any document, press release or stage introduction names her title.
- **Contact:** Smpesquire@outlook.com

Deacon Solomon Kibriye — the institution

- **Stated roles:** Deacon in the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church. Board chair of the Royal Ethiopian Trust, which he described as the charitable arm of the Ethiopian Crown Council — a crown institution geared toward charitable and cultural activity, registered as a 501(c)(3).
- **Public record:** The Royal Ethiopian Trust was announced on 1 October 2024 by Prince Ermias, who founded it. Published Crown Council material names Deacon Solomon Kibriye as President of the Trust. Its four stated pillars are education, Ethiopian entrepreneurship, preservation of imperial heritage, and support of the Crown. **VERIFY** Chair versus President — get the title right in writing.
- **Track record he claimed on the call:** educational charities inside Ethiopia and in the diaspora; disaster relief tied to hurricane damage in Jamaica; historic restitution of items looted from Ethiopia and held in Western hands since the late 1800s, specifically a shield of an emperor and the hairpin of his wife; and rebuilding a school that Emperor Haile Selassie I originally built near his birthplace in eastern Ethiopia, now near completion.
- **Public record on the restitution:** The Trust negotiated the return of a 19th-century ornamented shield taken by British troops after the 1868 Battle of Magdala, withdrawing it from a UK auction at Anderson & Garland, working with the Ethiopian historian Alula Pankhurst. It was displayed at the Toledo Museum of Art in October 2024 and returned to Ethiopia in November 2024, to the National Museum. This is real, verifiable, press-covered work.

- **Personal detail worth remembering:** His grandfather and great-uncle were jewelers to the Emperor and personally made the large silver processional cross that Haile Selassie I gave to Abyssinian Baptist Church in 1954, which the church still displays as an emblem in its sanctuary. His uncle holds a gold lion-head ring his father made. On 27 September he will be standing in a church that displays his own family's craftsmanship. That is the human story in this entire relationship.
- **What he asked for:** grassroots support in the African diaspora — North America, the Caribbean, anywhere. His words: "People who have a following in the African diaspora will help us build this platform that we need. Unity is power."
- **Contact:** (646) 498-9965

Lij Nebyat Aklilu Demessie — the operator

- **Stated roles:** Member of the Crown Council of Ethiopia, advisor to Prince Ermias, and directing much of the activity around the September events. Related to the Imperial house through his mother's side; he was careful to say he is not a direct descendant of the Emperor. **NOTE** "Lij" is an Ethiopian noble honorific. On the Zoom he appeared as "Neb Demessie."
- **His signature achievement:** He founded and led the **Selassie Stand Up** movement, a seven-year grassroots campaign to have a statue of Emperor Haile Selassie I erected. It succeeded: the African Union unveiled the statue on its Addis Ababa headquarters grounds in February 2019. He stressed that this was achieved against an openly hostile Ethiopian government of the day, and Deacon Solomon interrupted twice to say Lij Nebyat was being far too modest about it.
- **How he framed the pressure he faced:** the government tried to redirect him away from Pan-African framing, offering instead to build the statue in front of the Economic Commission for Africa. He refused, on the grounds that they did not need him or the diaspora to build a statue if the will was there — the offer was a detour away from the Pan-African movement.
- **Other work he cited:** accompanied Prince Ermias as advisor on the state visit to Jamaica, where he says it took twenty seconds to convince the Prime Minister to agree to a statue of His Majesty in Kingston — against seven years in Ethiopia. Works on renovation of Holy Trinity Cathedral. Organised a journey to the family's ancestral homeland in northern Shoa, where King Sahle Selassie held his palace before the seat of power moved and the line became emperors. Efforts to restore the tricolour flag. He named restoration of the monarchy as a long-term goal.
- **The northern Shoa trip he described:** thousands came out; Ethiopian Orthodox clergy brought out the *tabots*, the replicas of the Ark, and refused to take them back inside until the royal party arrived despite the delay. He called it magical. The African Union statue campaign also spurred a local movement in northern Shoa, where residents petitioned their administration to build a statue of Emperor Zera Yacob, the philosopher king — and the royal party ended up speaking beside it.
- **Public record:** The African Union unveiled the Haile Selassie statue at its headquarters on 10 February 2019. Crown Council and Ethiopian press coverage places Lij Nebyat Aklilu Demessie alongside Prince Ermias at official engagements, including an International Prayer Day for global peace in November 2024.

Not on the call, but the reason for it

His Imperial Highness Prince Ermias Sahle-Selassie Haile-Selassie — grandson of Emperor Haile Selassie I and President of the Crown Council of Ethiopia. He founded the Royal Ethiopian Trust in October 2024. He signed a

Memorandum of Understanding with the Government of Jamaica on 19 October 2022, with the Honourable Olivia Grange, agreeing to erect a statue of the Emperor in National Heroes Park, Kingston, and establishing cooperation across education, sport, culture, tourism and trade. He is the principal at both September events, and he is the person 19Keys has been escalated to meet.

04 The Conversation, In Full

This is the record of what was actually said, in order, so that 19Keys can pick any thread and pull it. Nothing here is summarised away.

Ms. Murray Powell's framing of why she reached out

She opened by naming what she saw at the 19Keys show in London: the focus on **economic sovereignty**, the empowerment message, sold-out large auditoriums, a young audience, a Pan-African focus, and what she called a bit of militancy. She said there is a lot of alignment there. That is the frame she is selling internally to the Crown Council: this platform reaches the young diaspora and speaks about ownership.

Deacon Solomon Kibriye on the Royal Ethiopian Trust

HIS POSITION The Trust is the charitable arm of the Crown Council — a crown institution, but geared toward charitable and cultural activity. Focus areas: educational charities in Ethiopia and the diaspora; disaster relief, particularly hurricane damage in Jamaica; and historic restitution of looted royal heritage. He named the shield of an emperor and the hairpin of his wife as recovered items, and pointed to press coverage. He described helping rebuild a school Emperor Haile Selassie I built near his birthplace in eastern Ethiopia, now in finishing work.

THE ASK The Trust was established roughly three years ago and is “just getting off the ground.” It needs to build grassroots support, and a big part of that base is the African diaspora — North America, the Caribbean, anywhere. “We want to be an emblematic part of what Ethiopianism is.”

HIS DOCTRINE OF ETHIOPIANISM Ethiopianism is unity, and it ties across religion. He is a deacon in the Orthodox Church, but he was explicit: Ethiopianism is not sectarian. There are Ethiopian Muslims, Ethiopian Christians, Ethiopian Jews. “Whatever your religious identity is, or whatever your ethnic identity is, is secondary to Ethiopianism. Ethiopianism is something that unites all of us.” He said it should not be hard to build a grassroots base for that, and that is where we can help.

Lij Nebyat Demessie on the work and the long game

ORIENTATION He described his own role as very grassroots. He recounted the Selassie Stand Up movement, the seven-year African Union statue campaign, the hostile government, and his refusal of the Economic Commission for Africa compromise. He credited collective effort and God's will; Deacon Solomon twice interrupted to insist he was underselling himself, noting that Ethiopians are raised not to toot their own horns and that many people could have made that stand but Lij Nebyat was the one brave enough to do it.

THE LARGER ARGUMENT He pushed the group past a narrow reading of the Crown. The Emperor, he argued, was an advocate of peace, collective security and denuclearisation, trying to bring the global world together under common laws and a common human identity. So the value of the Crown is not parochial and does not stop at Ethiopia's borders, and is bigger than a purely Pan-African framing. He said grassroots work is what makes people understand that value.

THE HISTORICAL THESIS — THE MOST IMPORTANT FIVE MINUTES OF THE CALL His claim: **Ethiopianism is what enabled Pan-Africanism to exist as a concept.** The Battle of Adwa in 1896, won under Emperor Menelik II, defeated the notion of white supremacy on the field, and Pan-Africanism was coined as a term in 1897.

Europeans could not swallow the defeat and responded by arguing that Ethiopians must not be Black. In 1900, at the global African conference, Ethiopia was represented through a Haitian proxy. What Menelik started, Haile Selassie built upon, and Europeans came to fear the Emperor as a beacon of hope for Black people worldwide.

THE SUPPRESSED HISTORY HE WANTS TOLD Nelson Mandela was trained in Ethiopia and given a passport under another name when exiled from South Africa, which he used to return and fight apartheid. The Mau Mau rebellion. His position: in effectively every conflict in Africa, the Emperor was at the forefront trying to bring peace and unity, and that history was suppressed after 1974. He noted the 1972–73 period, shifting ties, the Egypt-related vote, and the toppling of the monarchy in 1973–74.

THE OWNERSHIP QUESTION — PUT THIS IN FRONT OF 19KEYS His challenge: governments that have no interest in restoring the monarchy are nonetheless benefiting from the history of forefathers whose legacy those same governments suppressed. When B. Amechi raised ownership, Lij Nebyat sharpened it: “We understand there is inherent value in the assets and artifacts and traditions and culture of our forefathers. But who now is trying to own that and commodify that, and remove us from the ownership of what is rightfully ours? That is an important question to ask, because that is where the real challenge is.” That is the same thesis as Africa Plus, aimed at heritage instead of commodities.

PAN-AFRICANISM IN THE PRESENT He recalled sitting on a panel roughly three years ago convened by Dr. Julius Garvey on Africa for Africans, alongside a Howard University professor and others working to have Marcus Garvey’s record exonerated. The question posed was what Pan-Africanism means in the 21st century. His answer: anchoring movements around what we consider ours, around our own interests, with economics playing a large role.

THE TEMPLATE HE OFFERED He described being invited on state visits where African royalty was brought in to show a different side of Black identity to marginalised Black indigenous populations in Brazil, Panama and Colombia — and to build bridges and opportunities for those communities. He then offered, unprompted, to **share the Jamaica MOU** because it can be a replica for other places. He noted it went beyond the statue into alignment, law, and improving bilateral relations across sport, entertainment and music. **This is a concrete deliverable already promised to us.**

B. Amechi’s presentation of Africa Plus

THE STRATEGIC POINT Bringing people across the diaspora to see Ethiopia is one half. The other half is being strategic about the educational component and making sure high-level conversations are happening with the right people. Media is how the business runs — 19Keys is known first for the podcast — so it is not about the delegation in the room, it is about the millions who see the content afterward.

THE CREATOR ECONOMY ARGUMENT When IShowSpeed came to Africa it transformed the economy in several places. The moment demands seriousness about the creator economy and about working with people who understand it and have the infrastructure behind it. The person who brought Speed to Ethiopia, Nigeria and elsewhere is **ChakaBars**, and ChakaBars is leading our trip.

TRACK RECORD CITED Multiple trips to Ghana, Nigeria and Uganda, including a high-level conversation with the President of Uganda. Real connections made and parts of Africa shown to people who held a different perception of it.

THE AFRICA PLUS THESIS Africa Plus is essentially a trade agreement between the Black diaspora and Africa — actually doing business with each other, through media, tourism and real products. Supermind, the 19Keys coffee

business, was named as the live example, along with 19Keys' deep interest in Ethiopia because of coffee, soil and history. The goal is to work directly and cut out the middleman, rather than seeing coffee that had every resource to be finished in Ethiopia or Uganda processed somewhere else.

THE IP ARGUMENT Black Americans have enormous cultural influence globally and effectively export culture, but do not own the intellectual property of that culture. Africa historically holds the resources, but faces issues of ownership and control. Africa Plus exists to bridge that gap and build relationships with people who are serious about connecting the diaspora with Africa.

COMMITMENTS MADE ON THE CALL To connect Ms. Murray Powell, Deacon Solomon and Lij Nebyat directly with 19Keys as a next step. To send the trip deck, agenda and full details. To compile and circulate this summary with all links and information. To work with 19Keys and possibly ChakaBars on making the September travel happen and to be solution-focused about it.

THE CLOSING NOTE B. Amechi said that people often see what the team has built from afar, and that unity was the word of the call. Everyone has skill sets and everyone has gaps — especially entering a different country and culture, where you have to work with the right people on the ground, because it is easy to work with the wrong ones. He credited ChakaBars' existing connections and prior organising experience, and said it is always better to build with more people on the ground.

The Meskel explainer — Deacon Solomon Kibriye

Requested by Ms. Murray Powell so that the 19Keys side would understand why the September dates matter. His account, as given:

- The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church is one of the oldest Christian churches in the world, competing with the Armenian church for that title. It is an ancient apostolic church.
- Meskel celebrates the finding of the True Cross of Christ. The first Roman emperor to adopt Christianity was St. Constantine. His mother, Empress Helena, went to Jerusalem to find the holy places and built the Church of the Holy Sepulchre. Five churches have custody of the Holy Sepulchre; the Ethiopian Orthodox Church is one of them.
- Helena could not find the buried cross. Through divine revelation she built a bonfire and had incense thrown into it, and the smoke indicated where the Holy Cross was buried.
- Every year the Church builds a bonfire — the *Demera* — to commemorate that. Until 1974, the main bonfire in the Ethiopian capital was lit by **the Emperor himself**, mirroring Empress Helena in Jerusalem. The Imperial Army and armed forces paraded, the churches came out in procession, and it was, in his words, a very picturesque holiday.
- After the 1974 Communist revolution that ended. The Patriarch lights the bonfire now.
- New York City does not permit public bonfires without extensive insurance and fire department clearance. The only church in the New York metropolitan area that lights one is in **Newark, New Jersey**.
- This year that church asked **His Imperial Highness Prince Ermias** to light the bonfire. In Deacon Solomon's words, it is the first time a member of the Imperial family has lit a Meskel bonfire since 1974. He called it a landmark occasion.

Why this is the content asset, not the ceremony

A member of the Imperial house resuming a rite the Emperor performed until the monarchy fell — performed in exile, in Newark, in front of a diaspora congregation — is a documentary cold open. Fifty-two years of interruption ends on a Saturday evening twenty minutes from Manhattan. If we send one person with a camera and nothing else, we still win.

The Abyssinian Baptist Church history — Deacon Solomon Kibriye

- Abyssinian Baptist Church is one of the older African American churches in New York. Its founding story, as he told it: Ethiopian merchants or seamen came to a church in Manhattan in the early 1800s and were told to sit in a separate section because of their colour. They were so outraged that they left and started their own congregation, naming it after **Abyssinia**, the old Western name for Ethiopia.
- When fascist Italy invaded Ethiopia in 1936, the church was at the forefront of raising funds for the resistance. African Americans, through the Ethiopian World Federation, donated heavily to that effort — the direct line to Ms. Murray Powell's other organisation.
- In gratitude, on his 1954 state visit to the United States, Emperor Haile Selassie I visited Harlem and gave the church a **large silver processional cross**, which it still displays in its sanctuary as an emblem.
- Deacon Solomon's **grandfather and great-uncle made that cross** for the Emperor. They were jewellers to the Emperor.
- The church has visited Ethiopia several times as a group and remains involved in causes there.
- He will not attend the Abyssinian portion himself, because of Meskel obligations at the church he serves.

Public record note: Abyssinian Baptist Church was founded in 1808 and is one of the oldest Black congregations in the United States; Adam Clayton Powell Sr. and Adam Clayton Powell Jr. are its most famous pastors. Ms. Murray Powell said on the call she had a conversation that same day about possibly securing **Adam Clayton Powell III** as a speaker — because Adam Clayton Powell was critical to the Emperor's 1954 visit. Her phrasing: descendants of Adam Clayton Powell alongside descendants of His Imperial Majesty would make it even more historic.

Closing round — each person's final position

DEACON SOLOMON He said the coffee point struck him. His extension of it: people of colour in the West have all these resources, traditions and history that are ours, and have put them aside to put on a costume that is not ours — including political systems. Africa has long traditions and long history to draw from, but foreign concepts and foreign systems were adopted instead. He said it could easily be leather instead of coffee: Ethiopia exports huge quantities of leather, and then we buy Italian belts, shoes and purses. His conclusion: there is a way to empower our people and build on the pride they should have in this African legacy, and that is exactly where the Crown Council and the Royal Ethiopian Trust can partner with us. He confirmed the Saturday timing, addressed dress, said he would raise the luncheon question and was “pretty certain” we would be welcome, and said he was planning to be in Addis in January though other things in his life need to be resolved first, so it is a good possibility rather than a commitment.

LIJ NEBYAT He said the events will be epic and that there is a lot of history at Abyssinian Baptist Church. He confirmed **the events are being documented as part of a documentary**, describing a director flown in for a related Maryland engagement where he arranged for the county executive to speak and pushed the board to

extend proper protocol to the Prince. On the January trip he made three concrete offers: **send us the deck and he will review it and suggest additions**; he can help itemise and organise the tour for a group; and he has **contacts on the ground** and can make recommendations including for northern Shoa. He said he is relaunching the second chapter of Selassie Stand Up, waiting on the right moment, with events in Jamaica to bring everyone together. He invited direct email and phone contact.

MS. MURRAY POWELL She said she would share everyone's numbers so conversations continue offline — "I am not a gatekeeper." She flagged that **Ethiopian New Year falls on 11 September**. She offered to send the Crown Council New Year letter from last year, written by the Crown Council and His Imperial Highness, on collaboration between the monarchy, the government and innovation including the dam, calling the Crown Council letters informative and historical. She recommended the documentary "**Grandpa Was an Emperor**" as a modern history of the monarchy and its recovery after the Emperor was deposed, including the museum memorialising the Derg period, and said she has a cameo in it. It is a 2023 film, free on YouTube and available on Amazon Prime.

THE LINE TO HANDLE WITH CARE In closing, Lij Nebyat said he wants us to be "an extended voice of ours," because it is easier for non-Ethiopian nationals to express their free will and their aspirations without fear of retribution. That is candid and it is trust. It is also a request to carry political risk on their behalf. Section 12 addresses it.

05 New York, 26–27 September 2026

WHEN	WHAT	WHERE	STATUS
Sat 26 Sept 2:00 PM	Meskel eve — the Demera. Programme begins.	Debre Bisrat St. Gabriel Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Cathedral, Newark, New Jersey — the only church in the New York metro area permitted to light a bonfire	Open event. No cap on numbers. Come as you are.
Sat 26 Sept 4:00 PM	His Imperial Highness lights the bonfire — the first time a member of the Imperial family has done so since 1974	Same	Confirmed by Deacon Solomon on the call
Sun 27 Sept 10:00 AM	Meskel Day service. HIH visits, commemorating Emperor Haile Selassie I's 1954 Harlem visit	Abyssinian Baptist Church, Harlem, New York City	19Keys and guests are on the invited guest list. Formal letter of invitation promised.
Sun 27 Sept after service	Small private luncheon hosted by HIH — very small, closed circle	To be confirmed	Escalated, not confirmed. Deacon Solomon: "pretty certain" we will be welcome
Sun 27 Sept	Direct dialogue between 19Keys and HIH on economic development and the January visit	At the luncheon	Requested by Ms. Murray Powell. Awaiting confirmation.

Programme details still moving

- Speakers are still being added to the 27 September programme. Ms. Murray Powell was waiting on the church by email and planned to visit in person on Tuesday if she had not heard.
- She is pursuing **Adam Clayton Powell III** as a speaker, to pair Powell descendants with Imperial descendants.
- **Attire:** All white is encouraged and would be wonderful. Most attendees, including HIH and Deacon Solomon, will be in Ethiopian national dress. Nothing is required.
- **The weekend is being filmed for a documentary.** Establish before we arrive whether our crew shoots alongside theirs, whether footage is shared, and who owns what. Do not walk into someone else's documentary without a written understanding.

Cost reality — internal only

A three-person move to New York — 19Keys, B. Amechi and one content person — runs roughly **\$5,000 to \$7,500** for a short trip covering flights, lodging, ground transport and production. There is no committed budget for it today. Absent outside support, it comes out of the fourth-trip budget.

Recommendation: go regardless. The content value of a first-since-1974 Imperial rite, a Harlem church that has held an Emperor’s cross since 1954, and a potential direct conversation with the grandson of Haile Selassie is not replaceable at that price. If an Atlanta engagement can be booked around it, better. Ask for support, kindly and once — and go either way.

06 The January Expedition — What We Are Actually Selling

Element	Detail
Dates	5–15 January 2027 — eleven days
Route	Addis Ababa · Bishoftu crater lakes · Rift Valley lakes · Arba Minch · Nechisar National Park · Dorze highlands · Lalibela
Anchor moment	Gena — Ethiopian Christmas — 7 January
Capacity	Thirty seats. Hand-selected leaders, creators, investors and athletes.
Hosts	19Keys (conversation and community) · ChakaBars (wellness and movement) · Omega Axsal (expedition lead)
Price	\$3,500 per seat against a \$4,444 standard rate. Private room upgrade \$400. Shared same-gender room included.
Included	Accommodation for the full journey, domestic flights, ground transport, two to three meals daily, cultural access, wellness experiences, all three hosts, flight-booking support, visa guidance. A private in-trip mastermind.
Not included	International flights, travel insurance, visa fees, personal spending, drinks outside meals, tips, optional upgrades

Three things to fix before any of this goes to the Crown Council

- **The ticket page still shows an expired deadline.** The rate is presented as ending 10 August at 11:59 PM ET. That date passed nearly a month ago and the page is live today. Sending that link to a royal delegation makes the operation look unattended. Decide the current price and update the page first.
- **The delegation size is being quoted two ways.** The site and the partner deck say thirty seats. On this call the number given was “the hundred or so people that will be part of this delegation.” Pick one number and hold it everywhere — the Crown side will repeat whatever we say to their own contacts.
- **The partner page is the better link for this audience.** The Ethiopia trip page sells seats. The partner page at [this link](#) is the one built for governments, tourism bodies, hotels, operators, creators and sponsors — which is exactly who these three people are and who they will forward it to. It is now public. Send both.

07 What They Offered Us

OFFER	WHO	TURN IT INTO
Formal letter of invitation, guests included	Murray Powell	A document usable for travel authority, visas, sponsor decks and press. Ask for it on Crown Council letterhead with named guests.
Direct contact details for everyone, no gatekeeping	Murray Powell	Three independent lines into the Crown institution. Work all three, and keep her copied so she keeps her credit.
Escalation of 19Keys–HIH dialogue at the luncheon	Murray Powell	The single highest-value outcome of September. Chase to a written yes.
EWF proposal partnering Juvenile Units with 19Keys initiatives	Murray Powell	A youth and education programme with a chartered international body — grant-fundable, sponsor-fundable. Draft due roughly a week after the London tour stop.
EWF International Treasurer attending the London show	Murray Powell	A finance officer in the room. Get her a proper host, a seat and ten minutes.
Crown Council New Year letter and “Grandpa Was an Emperor”	Murray Powell	Primary-source briefing material for 19Keys before September.
Raising the luncheon invitation internally	Kibriye	Second channel to the same outcome.
Royal Ethiopian Trust as a charitable partner	Kibriye	A 501(c)(3) counterparty. This is the vehicle for sponsored seats, school builds and any grant-funded component.
Possible presence in Addis Ababa in January	Kibriye	Unconfirmed. Worth a direct invitation as a delegation guest.
Review of our January deck and itinerary	Demessie	Free expert audit from a man who organised royal travel in the same country. Send the deck this week.
Ground contacts and northern Shoa routing	Demessie	Access we cannot buy. Ask for named introductions, not general goodwill.
The Jamaica MOU as a replicable template	Demessie	The most underrated offer on the call. A working government-to-Crown agreement covering education, sport, culture, tourism and trade. Ask for the document.

08 What They Want From Us

- **A grassroots diaspora base for the Crown and the Trust.** Stated twice, plainly. The Trust is two years old and needs people, not just press.

- **Reach and legibility.** They want Ethiopianism understood beyond Ethiopia, beyond a narrow reading of the Crown, and beyond a purely Pan-African frame.
 - **Presence at the September events and the content that comes from it.**
 - **A January delegation that engages the monarchy's story** — the Emperor's birthplace, ancestral sites, descendants, relatives, and former Imperial bodyguards. Lij Nebyat named these specifically as things worth seeing and questions worth asking.
 - **An extended voice.** Their words, not ours. Handle deliberately — see Section 12.
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09 The Support Conversation

No money was discussed on the call. That is not a failure — introductions should not open with an invoice. But the ask has to be made in writing, once, clearly, before the next call, so that nobody is surprised on a live video with the Prince's advisors present. The wording that goes to them is in the partner-facing version of this brief. The reasoning is here.

The posture

We go regardless. We are grateful for the invitation and it is an honour. We also work one hundred percent independently — there is no institution or network behind 19Keys writing cheques — and a short move for three people costs real money. Anything helps. If direct funding is not available, introductions are worth as much. That is the whole message, said once, without apology and without pressure.

The asks, in priority order

1. **September travel support.** Three people to New York for the weekend. If the Crown side cannot fund it, can they connect us to those who can — sponsors, diaspora organisations, cultural funds, or their own network?
2. **Is there an ask of 19Keys?** Speaking, a panel, a blessing, a filmed conversation? If a speaking role exists, is there a speaking budget attached, or an organisation in the network that holds one?
3. **Travel authority and institutional cover** for January — letters, permits, ministry introductions, filming clearances.
4. **Media budget.** For documentary coverage of both the September weekend and the January expedition. If not from them, from partners they can name.
5. **In-country marketing support in Ethiopia.** Posts, flyers, church and community networks, local press. Tickets are available to Ethiopians as well as the diaspora, and we currently have no distribution inside the country. Their networks are the distribution.
6. **Sponsored seats.** Can the Royal Ethiopian Trust, or aligned nonprofits in their network, sponsor seats for people who could not otherwise travel? We operate a nonprofit vehicle on our side if a nonprofit-to-nonprofit structure is cleaner. **CONFIRM** Get the exact registered entity name before this goes out.
7. **A reading and viewing list.** Books, films and primary sources, from sources they trust, before January — so the history is told right and told from the right mouths. They have already started: "Grandpa Was an Emperor" and the Crown Council letters.

What we put on the table in return

- Documented global exposure through a platform with reach in the hundreds of millions, and the audience segment the Trust says it needs: young, diaspora, ownership-minded.

- Co-branded content and full credit. A named Crown Council and Royal Ethiopian Trust role in the January programming.
- A delegation carrying real capital — investors, operators, creators and athletes — not a camera crew.
- A track record of leaving something behind: a presidential sit-down that became a coffee contract, grants handed to five student teams on stage at the University of Lagos, schools and orphanages funded in Uganda and Ghana.
- A commitment to return every year, not a single visit.

10 Research Assignments

Before the next call, each of these should be answered by someone on our side. 19Keys should not walk into a room with the Prince's advisors carrying only what was said on a Sunday Zoom.

For 19Keys — the history and the posture

- Watch “**Grandpa Was an Emperor**” (2023). Free on YouTube, also on Amazon Prime and Apple TV. Ms. Murray Powell appears in it. It is the shortest path to the modern monarchy story and it gives him a shared reference with everyone in the room.
- Read the Crown Council's public statements and the Ethiopian New Year letter Ms. Murray Powell offered to send. Their letters are the clearest statement of where the Crown positions itself relative to the current government.
- Study the Battle of Adwa, 1896, and the coining of Pan-Africanism in 1897. Lij Nebyat's entire thesis rests on that sequence and he will expect it to land.
- Get the Mandela detail right. He trained in Ethiopia in 1962 and travelled on a passport under an assumed name. Naming it precisely signals that we did the work.
- Understand the 1974 rupture: the Derg, the deposition of Haile Selassie I, and why the Emperor stopped lighting the Meskel bonfire. That is the whole meaning of 26 September.
- Read the Jamaica MOU once Lij Nebyat sends it, and come to the next call with a view on what an Ethiopian equivalent would contain for us.

For ChakaBars — the ground and the risk

- Cross-check the itinerary against Lij Nebyat's northern Shoa suggestion. It adds monarchy-linked sites the standard Addis–Lalibela route does not carry — and it adds days, cost and logistics. Decide whether it is an add-on excursion or a route change.
- Assess whether Crown-linked programming creates any friction with government-side permissions, filming clearances or the operators already contracted. This is the operational half of the political question in Section 12.
- Confirm what the existing ground team can and cannot deliver on Crown-linked access, so we ask Lij Nebyat only for what we actually cannot get ourselves.
- Take a view on the documentary. Their crew is already filming the September weekend. Ours should not arrive without terms.

Verification tasks — assign to the team

- Ms. Murray Powell's current EWF officer status: International President or former President. Two different accounts exist.
- Deacon Kibriye's Trust title: board chair or President. Published Crown Council material says President.
- The Royal Ethiopian Trust's 501(c)(3) determination, EIN and filings — standard diligence before any nonprofit-to-nonprofit structure.
- The EWF's current corporate and leadership position. It is an old organisation with a long and sometimes contested institutional history. Confirm who speaks for it before we sign anything with it.
- The date of the London tour stop, which sets the delivery date for the EWF Juvenile Units proposal.

11 The Funnel — Where The Money Actually Is

The trip is not the business. Thirty seats is a proof of demand and a content engine. The Crown relationship is what turns it into an asset that compounds.

RUNG	OFFER	WHAT IT DOES
Free	The Africa Plus mission page and the Ethiopia partner page	Captures governments, operators, hotels, creators and sponsors into one intake sheet. Already live.
Free	September and January documentary content	The top of the funnel for every rung below. The Meskel bonfire is the hook.
Core	The January expedition — 30 seats	Cash now, and the credibility proof for everything after.
Premium	Delegation sponsorship — brands, diaspora institutions, nonprofits buying seats and placement	Where the September ask becomes a repeatable revenue line rather than a one-off favour.
Premium	Documentary rights and distribution	An owned asset with a shelf life measured in years, not a content cycle.
Anchor	Supermind × Ethiopian origin × Crown provenance	The million-dollar rung. Read below.
Recurring	An annual Meskel and Gena franchise, plus a High Lvl community tier for the Africa corridor	Turns one relationship into a calendar and a subscription.

The anchor play

Supermind sells coffee. Ethiopia is coffee's origin. Every specialty roaster on earth can print "single origin, Ethiopia" on a bag. Not one of them can carry a relationship with the house of Haile Selassie and a charitable partnership with the Trust that is rebuilding the school the Emperor himself built near his birthplace.

That is provenance, and provenance is the only moat in a commodity category. A Crown-linked Supermind Ethiopian line, tied to a school or entrepreneurship programme the Royal Ethiopian Trust already runs, does three things at once: it gives the Trust the grassroots economic engine it says it needs, it gives Supermind a story no competitor can replicate, and it gives Africa Plus its first true trade instrument — goods moving on a relationship, with value added at origin, exactly as pitched on the call.

Deacon Solomon handed us this himself when he extended the coffee argument to leather. He is already thinking in corridors. Do not leave it as philosophy.

12 God's Advocate

Everything above is the case for moving. Here is the case against, and the questions that should make us uncomfortable before the next call rather than after it.

1. We are being invited into a restoration movement, not a cultural exchange

Lij Nebyat said it directly: efforts to restore the tricolour flag, and to restore the monarchy as a long-term goal. He described a government hostile to the Crown, characterised the current administration's engagement with the royal family as inadequate, and framed governments as benefiting from a history they suppressed. That is a political position, and it is the position of the people extending the invitation.

Meanwhile the Africa Plus Ethiopia partner page is being sent by direct link to Ethiopian government and tourism bodies. **We are courting both sides of a contested question with the same document.** That is not automatically fatal — the Crown Council does hold state-level agreements, and the government did approve the African Union statue — but it must be deliberate. The counter-argument is that this fear is overstated: the Crown operates openly, signs MOUs with sovereign governments, and the Ethiopian state itself approved a monument to the Emperor. The rebuttal to that rebuttal is that approving a statue and welcoming a foreign media delegation that platforms restoration politics are two different tolerances.

The decision needed: one written sentence defining our position, agreed by 19Keys, and used identically with every party. The recommended posture is cultural, historical and commercial partnership with the Crown institutions, with no position taken on Ethiopia's internal constitutional questions. Say it before someone asks.

2. "An extended voice" is a request to absorb risk

The reasoning offered was that non-Ethiopian nationals can speak without fear of retribution. That is honest, and it is also an acknowledgement that speech carries consequences there. The people it does not protect are the Ethiopians on our ground team, our operators, our fixers, and any local partner whose name appears next to ours. Thirty travellers and a filming permit sit downstream of that.

3. The unity framing is itself contested inside Ethiopia

"Ethiopianism above ethnic identity" is a beautiful doctrine and a live political argument in a country organised around ethnic federalism. A diaspora platform arriving as a unity voice will be read by some as taking a side. We should be able to say what we mean by unity in our own words, in advance, rather than inheriting someone else's definition on camera.

4. Assume access, not cash

The Trust is two years old, describes itself as just getting off the ground, and said explicitly that it needs to build grassroots support. Organisations in that position are usually asking for reach, not writing cheques. Make the funding ask once, professionally, and then move the conversation to the assets they clearly do have: letters, introductions, ground contacts, ministry access, church and community distribution networks, and the Jamaica MOU template. Do not let a no on money read as a no on partnership.

5. Twenty days is not a plan

As of today there is no confirmed budget, no confirmed speaking slot, no confirmed luncheon seat, no confirmed meeting with the Prince, no crew booked and no documentary terms. Every one of those becomes harder each day. If 19Keys is going, the decision needs to be this week, and the asks need to go out with this brief rather than after it.

6. What we are risking is small, and that is the honest conclusion

Against all of the above: the downside of attending is a few thousand dollars and a weekend. The upside is a documented, first-since-1974 Imperial rite, a Harlem church that has held an Emperor's gift for seventy-two years, three institutional relationships, and a possible face-to-face with the grandson of Haile Selassie three months before we land in his country. The risk is not in going. The risk is in going without a position, without terms, and without the ask in writing.

13 Next Steps

This week — owner: B. Amechi

- ☐ Circulate this brief to 19Keys, ChakaBars and Omega Axsal. Get a yes or no on New York, and the travel roster if yes.
- ☐ Agree the one-sentence political position with 19Keys before any further contact with the delegation.
- ☐ Fix the ticket page: remove the expired 10 August deadline and set the current rate.
- ☐ Settle the delegation number — thirty or otherwise — and align the site, the deck and every conversation.
- ☐ Confirm the exact registered name of our nonprofit vehicle before the sponsored-seat ask goes out.
- ☐ Send the partner-facing brief to Ms. Murray Powell, Deacon Kibriye and Lij Nebyat, with the trip deck attached and all three links included.

Mid-week — the full delegation call

B. Amechi has already proposed mid-week to Ms. Murray Powell and she is expecting it. Target Wednesday 9 or Thursday 10 September.

- ☐ **Our side:** 19Keys, B. Amechi, ChakaBars, Omega Axsal.
- ☐ **Their side:** Ms. Murray Powell, Deacon Solomon Kibriye, Lij Nebyat Aklilu Demessie — and, if reachable, a representative able to speak to the Prince's schedule on the 27th.
- ☐ **Agenda:** introductions to 19Keys directly, confirmation of the September programme and the luncheon, the support conversation, the itinerary review with Lij Nebyat, and the documentary terms.

Friday 11 September — Ethiopian New Year

Ms. Murray Powell flagged the date and it is the correct campaign launch moment for the January expedition. One asset, one story, one link, sent to the Africa Plus list, both communities, and to the Crown side to amplify into Ethiopian and diaspora networks.

Before 20 September

- ☐ Letter of invitation received, with named guests.
- ☐ Travel, lodging and crew locked for 26–27 September.
- ☐ Documentary terms agreed in writing with the Crown side's production.
- ☐ Luncheon and HIH dialogue confirmed or formally closed out.
- ☐ Trip deck sent to Lij Nebyat for review, with his notes returned.

Standing follow-ups

- ☐ Jamaica MOU document requested from Lij Nebyat.
- ☐ Ground contacts and northern Shoa recommendations requested as **named introductions**.
- ☐ Crown Council New Year letter requested from Ms. Murray Powell.

- ☐ EWF Juvenile Units proposal tracked to delivery, one week after the London stop.
- ☐ EWF International Treasurer hosted properly at the London show.
- ☐ Deacon Kibriye invited formally to join the January delegation in Addis.

The decision on the table

19Keys: yes or no on New York, 26–27 September, and the travel roster. Everything else in this document is sequenced behind that answer. Ready to execute on your word.

14 Links and Sources

Our links — the three that go out with every message

- **The Africa Plus mission** — what we are building and why. [Open the Africa Plus site](#)
- **Ethiopia partner page** — for governments, tourism bodies, hotels, operators, creators, investors and sponsors. [Open the Ethiopia partner page](#)
- **Ethiopia trip page** — the expedition overview inside the Africa Plus site. [Open the Ethiopia trip page](#)
- **Ethiopia booking page** — dates, inclusions and seat reservation. [Open the booking page](#)

Sources consulted for this brief

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- The Crown Council of Ethiopia — agreement with the Government of Jamaica, 19 October 2022: ethiopiancrown.org
- Capital Ethiopia — Royal Ethiopian Trust negotiates return of the Magdala shield, 14 October 2024: capitalethiopia.com
- African Union — unveiling of the Haile Selassie I statue, 10 February 2019: au.int
- Borkena — Prince Ermias and Lij Nebyat Aklilu Demessie at International Prayer Day, November 2024: borkena.com
- Scheril Murray Powell, Esq. — professional profile: scherilspeaks.com
- The Ethiopian World Federation, Inc. — founding, 25 August 1937: tewfinc.org
- “Grandpa Was an Emperor” (2023) — DOC NYC: docnyc.net
- Abyssinian Baptist Church history, founded 1808: [Wikipedia](#)
- Crown Council of Ethiopia — institutional background: [Wikipedia](#)
- Primary source: B. Amechi’s recording and transcript of the call, 6 September 2026, and the text thread with Ms. Murray Powell, 1 October 2025 to 6 September 2026.